programme soon. However, experts say that waiting for mRNA boosters is not needed and at the moment, added immunity is more important.

India is also resuming its five-fold Covid strategy: test, track, treat, vaccinate and adhere to Covid-appropriate behaviour. Since the January 2022 wave in India, the world has seen over 10 more infectious sub-variants of Omicron. Even during periods of small surges, such as the one in July 2022, when the BA.2.75 was detected in India, the number of deaths stayed at an average of around 40 per week. At present, the four new cases of BF.7 in India have shown only mild symptoms. "There is no need to panic as we are keeping a strict eye on new variants and signs of major outbreaks. But one should not be complacent—boosters should be taken and rules must be followed," says Dr Arora. There are no clear answers for whether the Covid pandemic has run its course. And until we have one, it's best to stick to what we know for certain: precaution is the best strategy. ■



THE REBOUND Bhim Army's Chandrashekhar Azad (left) with RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary

UTTAR PRADESH

JAYANT BETS ON JATS, JATAVS AND MORE

By Prashant Srivastava

The bypoll wins in the Mainpuri Lok Sabha seat and Rampur and Khatauli assembly constituencies in Uttar Pradesh have brought several positives for the opposition Samajwadi Party (SP) and Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). The Khatauli seat, which it wrested from the ruling BJP after a long time, could emerge as a gamechanger for the opposition, especially for the Jayant Chaudhary-led RLD.

Chaudhary's experiment in bringing the Jat, Gujjar, Muslim and Dalit communities under one fold worked in Khatauli, where the RLD's Gujjar candidate Madan Bhaiyya defeated the BJP's Rajkumari Saini. Just before the election, firebrand Dalit leader Chandrashekhar Azad's Azad Samaj Party also announced their support to the SP-RLD alliance, which too played a major role in the victory of the alliance.

Jayant has announced that the alliance will continue till the 2024 general election. His push to bring the Jats and Jatavs (a Dalit community) together has raised some tension in the BJP camp as the party has high hopes for Uttar Pradesh's 80 Lok Sabha seats (the BJP alliance has 65 seats now).

Together, the Jats, Jatavs, Gujjars and Muslims make up over 40 per cent of the population of western UP. Jayant's coup in bringing in Bhim Army chief Azad and sealing the pact with the SP has shifted the focus to the castes. "The message from the Khatauli bypolls has gone to the whole sugarcane belt of UP where the government has not fulfilled the expectations of farmers. We are young leaders, me, Akhilesh (Yadav) and Chandrashekhar, and the public